

stating the truth. It has never been up to the communists to withdraw support. Why should they? The comrades have never had it so good.

For more than three years, they have been supporting and opposing the UPA Government with remarkable dialectical flair. On reforms in PSUs and banking, they held the Government to ransom. They alone had the freedom to issue fatwas against the Government and sustain it at any cost. They played this double role within the Parliament and on the street. With 59 members—43 of the CPI(M)—in the Lok Sabha, the Left is permanently aware of its veto power, that too without any administrative responsibility. The Government, on its part, indulged the Marxists, consistently. Even on the nuclear deal, the Left's opposition has reportedly made Manmohan a better negotiator with the Americans. When he realised that what Karat really wanted was to drag the cadaver of the deal across the electoral market as a victory of the Indian working class over American imperialism, Manmohan had to show that he could not be taken for granted, certainly not on an issue that he hoped would earn him a place in history. So he challenged his tormentor.

**T**he prime minister would soon come to know that the tormentor was a tough man to please. He invited him for a peace breakfast of dosa, buttered toast, omelette and fresh fruit to 7 Race Course Road. Even the presence of Pranab Mukherjee, the UPA's chief troubleshooter, was not much of a help on August 14. The generally reticent Karat smiled when Manmohan asked him if there was a way out. "We don't agree with your position, you don't agree with ours," the CPI(M) general secretary is said to have replied. The PM issued a statement that captured the futility of the breakfast meeting: "Shri Karat and the prime minister reiterated that efforts would be made to sort out the issues." After Karat's visit, Manmohan telephoned CPI boss A.B.

Bardhan to invite him for a discussion. Bardhan, who by then had already been briefed by Karat on the outcome of the breakfast meeting, turned down the request saying, "I know what Prakash told you. I have nothing new to add. So, let's not waste time in another meeting." Unable to breach the red wall of Delhi, the prime minister looked east later in the day, seeking West Bengal Chief Minister Buddhadeb Bhattacharya's intervention in the CPI(M) politburo. Although the chief minister has been inspired by Manmohan's economic reforms, it seems unlikely that he will defend the prime minister's cause at his party's highest decision-making body, especially when the operative word is America. "The nuclear agreement is no longer in the realm of Parliament. We now have to take a political position on it," Karat told INDIA TODAY.

More than political positions, political compulsions are at play. The aggressiveness of the prime minister owes a great deal to the inner fears of the Marxists, who are caught between two difficult choices. For the comrades, the survival of the 'secular' Government is as important as the death of the nuclear deal. And anti-Americanism is one slogan that the Left hopes can mobilise the Muslim vote even in India. Who is the bigger enemy, BJP or George Bush? They have to answer this difficult question before punishing Manmohan. The prime minister knows that the Left cannot easily translate threats into decisive action. He is getting a bit clever too. The red parivar is not a united house, and that is why he is turning to potential Dengs like Buddhadeb for help. In doing so, he is, perhaps unknowingly, taking a leaf out of Indira Gandhi's



book. Though she was AICC president when the first communist government in Kerala was dismissed in 1957, she maintained a good relationship with the comrades from West Bengal. Her government could survive the 1969 split only with the help of communist leaders like Jyoti Basu.

The prime minister must have been smirking somewhere in the privacy of 7 Race Course Road when Leader of the Opposition L.K. Advani called up Karat, asking him to join in a vote against the deal. Advani didn't expect Karat would go for a red-saffron assault. Karat might have found the invitation rather embarrassing, and that, perhaps, was what Advani wanted. How is the Left going to strike a balance between its anti-BJPism, anti-Americanism and secular solidarity? Nuclear diplomacy has made Manmohan politically smarter. BJP seems to have forgotten that it was the Atal Bihari Vajpayee government which laid the foundation for India's active engagement with the US. Manmohan is only building on

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